FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

It is a story that an ace crime thriller writer may think too daring to write. And presuming one of them did venture to try, even a master of delicate plots would completely lose his tracks in this thicket of deceptions. A Bollywood director well-rehearsed in pulling off unbelievable capers on screen too might pause for breath when listening to this tale. Imagine a confidence trickster who can fool both politicians and businessmen—that would be the highest attainment in the art. This week, therefore, we take a break from affairs of the state to profile a young con meister from the south whose dizzying trail of exploits and sleights of hand by now cover the land. Meet Sukash Chandrashekhar, for whom a hard-bitten Tamil politician was just one among a long list of prey he hooked with choice bait. He allegedly asked for Rs 50 crore there, on the promise of getting a favourable ruling from the Election Commission on a famous party symbol.

His biggest heist, though, was conducted upon the hapless wife of well-known industrialist Shivinder Mohan Singh, a former co-promoter of Ranbaxy and Fortis Healthcare, who had been jailed in Delhi's Tihar in a money-laundering case in 2019. Using a mix of threats and blandishment, he conned Shivinder's wife Aditi Singh into parting with Rs 200 crore by promising to get her husband out of prison. For this, he masqueraded as the Union law secretary and as the Union home secretary—using an app to have their official central government phone numbers show up on the receiver's phone. During the first lockdown of 2020, he managed to inveigle her into a false sense of hope with the idea that the government would be willing to pardon her husband and take him on in an advisory role on health, if they contributed to party funds. Payments were made out abroad and in India, the latter mostly through the good offices of a jeweller, a hawala operator and a bank manager who knew how to liquefy investments.



October 6, 1997

The most remarkable thing about this scheme was that, by the time sleuths started tracking the calls, they realised the whole operation was being conducted from inside a Delhi jail, where Sukash was cooling his heels for trying to bribe EC officials. But then, morph his prison cell into a luxury suite as he had got a whole line-up of jail officials on his side with wads of cash. The stories are now tumbling out because the ace impersonator who can mimic like a parrot is also, happily for investigators, singing like a canary. By now, his list of victims—across six states—has lengthened to nearly a thousand. From gullible people of all stripes—corporate honchos to chowkidars to bank officials—he has swindled an estimated Rs 500 crore. And his acquisitions are eye-catching. A fleet of top-end imported cars—Rolls Royce, Maserati, Lamborghini, Ferrari and Porsche. In all, 54 of them, with a combined worth of more than Rs 35 crore. That's besides 85 watches worth Rs 18 crore.

The 33-year-old Sukash had started early, as a teenager in Bengaluru, a harmless-looking but smooth-talking public school boy with a burning desire to erase the memory of a lower-middle-class background. He was the son of a rubber contractor and part-time mechanic. But he devised innumerable ways to mask that. Often, he simply posed as a VVIP. In 2009, when he was 20 years old, he introduced himself as the son of a Karnataka minister to execute a con. As he scaled up his game, he took to posing as the grandson of then Tamil Nadu chief minister M. Karunanidhi. A whiz with a phone, he was also remarkably thorough with his homework and with his reconnoitering—which is why he could don any number of masks in convincing ways. If he could introduce himself as an additional director of the Karnataka State Development Project to dupe businessmen on the promise of procuring tenders and contracts, he could also pull off an act as a joint secretary in the CM's office. And then, further up the evolutionary ladder, the Union law minister's secretary and even a Supreme Court justice.

He also has touches of a Casanova. Besides his wife, a B-movie actress from Kerala who eventually joined him in the life of smooth crime, he seemed to have a general yen for famous women from cinema. Those who allegedly fell for his lure include Bollywood actress Jacqueline Fernandez, whom he impressed first by putting out the word that he was a home ministry official close to top politicians in New Delhi. Or, depending on which version you believe, that he was the son of Sun TV's owner. He showered her with all manner of expensive gifts, including Birkin bags, diamonds, fancy cars and chartered flights. Their relationship seemingly came to acquire overtones of intimacy and was much speculated upon, though Jacqueline denies any romantic liaison. He did fish for a handful of other actresses, all of them famous and beautiful. They are now being questioned by the ubiquitous Enforcement Directorate for any links with, or leads on, Sukash.

But putting together a story that spans over 15 years and 30 cases—in none of which he has been convicted till now—required a whole journalistic posse doing sleuthwork. With India Today TV Deputy Editor Munish Chandra Pandey providing the leads from the ED and Associate Editor Ajay Sukumaran doing the police procedural on Sukash's early years in Bengaluru, digging up old chargesheets and interviewing policemen who dealt with his cases, Executive Editor Kaushik Deka weaves the threads together to profile a guy who has to be one of the most incredible conmen in modern India.

In one sense, Sukash Chandrashekhar is the very antithesis of everything that is right—but he is also a by-product of everything that is wrong with our times. Being unethical and hyper-acquisitive seems to be a common affliction. If there was a university for financial crime, he would be a professor there. The highest punishment in the various cases registered against him is 10 years in prison, but if convicted in all, Sukash could well be in jail for life. That, as he demonstrated in the industrialist case, did not bar him from carrying out his nefarious activities, though. What needs fixing is the entire criminal justice system too if such serial criminals have to be deterred.



(Aroon Purie)